



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Grooming: A Guide for Parents

Spotting the signs of grooming, talking with your child without blame, setting up devices, and what to do if you are worried.

Before You Read This guide covers grooming for sexual abuse, exploitation and radicalisation.

This guide is about grooming: when someone builds a relationship with a child, and sometimes with their family, in order to abuse or exploit them. It mentions sexual abuse, images and exploitation, without graphic detail. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with your own experience or your child's.

- If you are worried about your child now, contact the school's safeguarding team. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000, for anyone worried about a child.

About This Guide

Grooming is when someone builds a child's trust, and a position of power over them, in order to abuse or exploit them. This guide helps you spot the signs, talk with your child without blame, set up their devices, and know what to do, and what not to do, if you are worried.

- It can happen online or offline, by a stranger or by someone the family knows and trusts, including other young people.
- It can lead to sexual abuse, criminal exploitation or radicalisation.
- Children who are being groomed often don't know it. They may believe they are in a caring relationship, and may defend the person.

If You Think Your Child Is in Danger Now

- If your child is going to meet someone they met online, has gone missing, or is in immediate danger, **call 999**.
- If someone is asking your child for sexual images, threatening them, or trying to meet them, report to the police or CEOP, and tell the school's safeguarding team.

- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency):** ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, or worries about the way someone has been communicating with a child online. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking.
- **Don't contact the person, and don't delete anything.**

What the Evidence Shows

7,263

offences of sexual communication with a child recorded by 44 UK police forces in a year

NSPCC, 2025

80%

of children targeted were girls, where gender was known. Boys are targeted too

NSPCC, 2025

The number recorded has almost doubled since 2017/18. These are recorded crimes only. Checked September 2026.

How Grooming Works

- **Trust:** attention, flattery and understanding. The person may present as a friend, mentor, boyfriend or girlfriend, and may pretend to be younger.
- **Gifts and favours:** money, game credit, phones, clothes or lifts, which can later become debts.
- **Secrecy and isolation:** asking the child to keep the friendship secret, and turning them against family and friends.
- **Testing and control:** pushing boundaries a little at a time, moving to private apps, asking for images, or suggesting a meeting.
- Some groomers befriend the family too, so parents trust them.

Based on NSPCC Learning.

Signs to Look For

Age	What you might notice
8 to 11	A new "friend" in a game or app who gives them in-game gifts; secrecy about a device; worry about losing the device if they tell

Age	What you might notice
11 to 14	An older online friend; gifts or money you can't explain; hiding their screen; dropping old friends
14 to 18	A much older partner; being picked up by people you don't know; going missing; new possessions, a second phone, or new views that sound like someone else's

- Changes in mood, sleep or behaviour; spending much more or less time online
- Sexual language or knowledge you wouldn't expect for their age

Any one sign can have an innocent explanation. **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before contacting the school.**



Talking With Your Child

- **Talk often** about their online life in everyday moments: who they play and chat with, not only when something goes wrong.
- **Stay calm and curious.** "Tell me about your new friend." Avoid "why" questions, which can sound like blame.
- **Criticise the behaviour, not the person** your child likes: "A safe adult wouldn't ask you to keep secrets from me."
- **Make it safe to tell:** "Whatever has happened, you won't be in trouble for telling me." Taking the phone away can feel like punishment and stop them telling you next time.
- **Explain secrets and surprises:** a surprise ends happily; a secret that feels worrying should always be shared.



Online Settings

- Use privacy settings so only people your child knows can contact them, and turn off location sharing with people they don't know.
- Check who can message them in games and apps, including voice chat.
- Use parental controls suited to their age, and talk about them together; controls are not a substitute for conversation.
- Agree family rules: never arrange to meet someone they only know online, and never share images of their body. If they have already agreed to meet someone, they shouldn't go, and they won't be in trouble for telling you.

- **CEOP Education (National Crime Agency):** ceopeducation.co.uk/parents, advice for parents on grooming, conversation starters and parental controls.

If You Suspect Grooming

Do

- **Listen and believe.** Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- **Keep everything as it is.** Don't delete messages or accounts. Write down what your child said, and when.
- **Contact the school's safeguarding team**, the police (101, or 999 in an emergency) or CEOP.
- Keep your child close and safe, especially if a meeting has been suggested.

Don't

- **Don't confront or message the person**, even to warn them off. It can put your child at more risk and lead to evidence being deleted.
- Don't post about it online or try to find out who they are.
- **Never screenshot, save, forward or share a nude or sexual image of a child**, even of your own child and even as evidence. Tell the police or school instead. **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.
- Don't blame your child. Groomers are skilled at making children feel responsible.

If Another Child May Be Involved

If your child may have been introducing other children to the person, or another child may be at risk, **contact the school's safeguarding team before raising it with your child**. Agree how and when to talk to them, so the conversation doesn't increase the risk to anyone, for example by alerting the person or leading to messages being deleted.

If It's Someone at School or a Club

- Grooming can be carried out by people who work with children. If you are worried about a member of staff, volunteer or coach, **tell the headteacher** (or, if it is about the headteacher, the chair of governors or the proprietor). Clubs and organisations should have their own safeguarding lead.
- Local authorities have a designated officer (LADO) who oversees allegations against people who work with children, and the school will involve them where needed.
- If a child may be in danger, contact the police.

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice the signs, including gifts, secrecy and older online friends
● Engage	Listen calmly and without blame; never confront the person
● Support	Make sure the child is safe today, especially if a meeting is planned
● Pause	Think before acting; don't investigate, search phones or alert the person
● Offer	Model what safe relationships look like, and explain what happens next
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team as soon as is practicably possible, and immediately where there is risk
● Document	Record what happened, factually

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe.** You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you when there is a concern about your child.

- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.
- The safeguarding lead decides, with the police where involved, how evidence is kept and who is contacted. Staff won't copy or forward images of children.
- A child who has been groomed is treated as a victim, whatever they have been drawn into.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's always a stranger"	Many children are groomed by someone they, or their family, already know.
"My child would tell me"	Groomers work hard to make children keep secrets, and many children don't realise it is grooming.
"Taking the phone away will fix it"	It can feel like punishment for telling, and the contact may move somewhere else. Work with the school.
"I should confront them"	Confronting the person can put your child at more risk and lose evidence. Go to the police, CEOP or the school.

Who Can Help

At School

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency):** ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, or worries about the way someone has been communicating with a child online. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking
- **CEOP Education (National Crime Agency):** ceopeducation.co.uk/parents, advice for parents on grooming, conversation starters and parental controls
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline:** 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, any time, or childline.org.uk
- **Emergency:** call 999; police non-emergency: 101

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Grooming: A Guide for Parents: Parent Guide 31 - Ages 8 to 18

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